

Neck-Deep In The Shit, Sergeant

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

He came back to himself slowly, the way a man surfaces from deep water — aware of light before he was aware of anything else, then sound, then the specific and detailed inventory of everything that hurt.

The ground was cold beneath his cheek. His helmet had been pushed sideways by something that had left a dent in the metal he could feel pressing against his temple, and his head responded to movement with a bright, insistent wrongness.

He lay still for a moment and let the world assemble itself.

The battle. The line collapsing on the left flank. Briggs shouting something — an order, a warning, he couldn't recall which — and then the impact, and then nothing, and in the nothing, just before the dark took him completely, the image of two boots dragging across churned earth. Small boots. Gnome-sized.

Blackhoof got up.

He stood with his legs braced until shaking stopped.

The field around him was quiet in the way battlefields went quiet after — not peaceful, but emptied. The sounds of fighting had moved elsewhere or ended entirely, and what remained was the specific silence of a place that had been loud and wasn't anymore.

Men left, crows began gathering for a feast.

He found water in a fallen pack nearby — drank carefully, waited, drank again — and then began to move through the field with the methodical attention of a man who could not afford to miss anything. The dead around him were mostly goblin, some wearing colours he recognised. He took what he needed without ceremony: a helmet that fit, a shield that wasn't cracked through, a war hammer with a good balance. From a fallen centaur whose face he didn't look at. He took a brace of javelins and a short sword, plain and serviceable. Briggs's spare weapons, if he needed them.

The longbow was lying across a broken cart, unstrung but intact, the quiver beside it still fat with arrows. He had been training with one for three weeks — badly, by his own assessment, but consistently. He picked it up. Strung it. Tested the pull and felt his vision swim briefly with the effort.

He waited for it to clear. Then he turned toward camp.

The camp told the story plainly enough.

Tents pulled down or burned. Supplies scattered or taken. The goblin dead left where they lay, because the victors hadn't cared enough to move them and the defeated hadn't had time. The army had gone — east, by the track of it, which was the direction of retreat and not the direction of anything good.

Blackhoof stood at the edge of the camp and understood, without anyone having to explain it, that there was no one left to report to.

He walked the perimeter anyway. Looking.

Something caught his eye. A small glitter. In the grass he found the flask. Very well known one. It was lying on its side in the mud, dented.

The track beside it was heading northwest. Away from the retreat. Away from everything, into the trees, and the footprints around it were large and heavy and not goblin.

Blackhoof held the flask for a moment.

He thought about the eastern track. The main column, somewhere ahead of him, which was where a soldier was supposed to go when his unit was routed and his sergeant was — when the situation was unclear. That was the correct thing. That was the thing Briggs himself would probably tell him to do, in the flat, pragmatic tone he used for things that were obvious.

Follow the column. Report in. Don't do anything stupid.

He ate what he could find in the ransacked stores — not much, but enough — and filled his water skin and checked the bow one more time.

Then he moved.

He smelled the fire before he saw the light of it, which was either luck or instinct and he didn't particularly care which. He slowed, moved off the track into the treeline, and came at it from an angle that kept the wind behind him and the noise of his approach absorbed by the undergrowth.

Through the trees, the fire resolved into a camp — small, temporary, the kind made by men who intended to move on in the morning. Three orcs. A heap of gear that had clearly come from the goblin camp — packs, weapons, a roll of good canvas. And at the edge of the firelight, tied to a tree with his arms behind him and his chin on his chest, Briggs. Alive!

Actually he was just yelling at the orcs at the top of his lungs. Probably because their camp was poorly set up, or maybe he'd spotted some minor flaw in their uniforms. It didn't matter; to Blacky, it was the best sound he'd heard all day.

Centaur watched for a long moment.

His head was still not entirely his own. The firelight moved in ways that firelight wasn't supposed to, and when he raised the bow the first time, the sight line shifted and he had to lower it and breathe and wait for his vision to settle. The orcs were talking among themselves in their own language, unhurried, the tone of men who had made a good day's work and knew it.

He raised the bow again.

Pick a point. Don't think about the rest.

He released.

The arrow went wide — not by much, but wide, burying itself in the tree six inches from the nearest orc's shoulder. The orc turned his head, looked at the arrow, and looked at the treeline with an expression of professional irritation.

Blackhoof had already nocked the second.

This one didn't miss.

Nor did the third, which was in the air before the second had landed.

He was moving before the last orc fell, out of the treeline and into the firelight with the war hammer in hand.

The fight was brief and ugly and he took a glancing blow to the shoulder that he'd feel tomorrow, and then it was over and he was standing in the firelight breathing hard, and Briggs was watching him from the tree with an expression that was difficult to read at this angle.

Blackhoof crossed to him and drew the short sword to cut the ropes.

"Hello there" Briggs started.

"Neck deep in the shit, sergeant?" It was more ironic than warm, but it was a long day.

Working at the knots. Nearly through. Briggs's voice dropped, suddenly urgent and very quiet: "Blacky. What did we say yesterday about orcs."

Not a question. A specific, pointed reminder. The tone of a teacher who has just watched a student make the exact mistake he warned them about.

Blackhoof turned.

The orc — the first one, the one the arrow had taken in the chest — was on its feet. Not steady. Not entirely functional. But upright, and the sword in its hand was moving, and the distance between them was nothing at all.

The block was instinct. The short sword came up and caught the blade and turned it, and the impact ran all the way up his arm to the shoulder that was already complaining, and for a moment they were very close, close enough to see the particular expression of something that had decided it was not done yet.

Blackhoof stepped back. Reset.

The orc swung again, slower now.

He let it miss, and hit it with the hammer.

The sound was final. The orc left the ground briefly and landed in the darkness beyond the firelight and did not move again. Blackhoof stood with the hammer at his side and waited, watching the shape on the ground, until he was certain.

Then he went back to Briggs and finished cutting the ropes.

Briggs stood, slowly, with the careful movements of a man checking his own inventory. He rolled his shoulders. Flexed his hands. Looked at the three orcs with the expression of a man who wanted to be sure.

"The heads," he said.

"It's your job." It may have sounded colder than was meant.

Briggs did it efficiently and without discussion, because an orc that couldn't be killed permanently was a problem that didn't need to be left for someone else.

Afterward, Briggs retrieved his flask from Blackhoof's belt where he'd clipped it, opened it, found it empty, and looked at it for a moment.

"There's a full one in that pack," Blackhoof said, nodding at the stolen gear.

Briggs found it. Drank. Offered it across without comment.

They sat by the fire and let the night settle around them, and Blackhoof ate the last of what he'd taken from the camp, and his head ached with a deep, established persistence that suggested it intended to stay for several days, and it was, on balance, a better situation than it had been an hour ago.

"The army pulled east," Blackhoof said eventually.

"Did they."

"The stolen gear fills a wagon. We could take it back with us."

"We could."

"In the morning."

"Sounds like a plan."

Briggs stared into the fire for a while. Then, with the careful precision of a man choosing his words for maximum accuracy:

"I want to be clear," he said, "that following an enemy track into a forest at dusk, alone, without informing anyone, in pursuit of a single captive sergeant of no particular strategic importance, is exactly the kind of tactically unsound, operationally reckless, profoundly undisciplined decision that I have spent considerable effort trying to train out of you."

Blackhoof said nothing.

"It is the sort of thing a green recruit does. Someone who still thinks wars are stories and sergeants are characters in them." He took another pull from the flask. "Someone who has not yet learned the difference between courage and sentimentality."

"You're welcome," Blackhoof said.

A pause.

"Furthermore," Briggs continued, at the same measured pace, "your first shot missed by a mile, which suggests you were either concussed or undertrained, and given that I have personally overseen your training, I am choosing to attribute it to the concussion for reasons that reflect well on neither of us."

"The concussion," Blackhoof confirmed.

"Yes." Briggs looked at the fire. Something moved in his face, briefly, that the firelight made difficult to identify precisely. "Still, it was an excellent ambush and given to the circumstances, you fought like a lion!"

Blackhoof blushed and tried to say something, but Briggs continued with usual voice.

"We leave at first light."

"First light," Blackhoof agreed, taking a deep breath, but blush stayed for a while.

He settled back and looked out past the edge of the firelight, where the trees thinned and the sky opened up and the darkness in that direction had a quality of distance to it — the particular depth of landscape that went on for a long way before it stopped.

"I wonder," he said to himself, "what's out there. Over the horizon." A pause. "What would be waiting, if the army wasn't."

Briggs pretended to be already sleeping, but he heard.

Somewhere behind his closed eyes, in the place where he kept the things he noticed and didn't mention, he filed it away. The way the young centaur looked at the horizon — not with the recruiter's hunger, not the desperate appetite for glory he had arrived with all those months ago. Something quieter than that.

Briggs snored, Blacky didn't notice, boys mind already somewhere far far away...

